

95 Micah

A country prophet who named the sins of the powerful and pointed to a ruler from Bethlehem.

Micah came from Moresheth, a small town in the lowlands of Judah, far from the palaces of Jerusalem. He prophesied in the days of Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah, at the same time as Isaiah. He saw what the powerful were doing to ordinary families: seizing fields and houses, bribing judges, and hiring prophets to say what they wanted to hear. Micah warned that Samaria would fall and that even Jerusalem would be ploughed like a field. A century later, his words were remembered at Jeremiah's trial, because King Hezekiah had listened and repented. Micah also foretold a ruler from little Bethlehem, and he summed up God's will in one of the Bible's best-known sentences: do justly, love mercy, walk humbly with God.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Mikah</i> , short for "Who is like the LORD?"
Home	Moresheth, probably Moresheth-gath in the lowlands of Judah (Micah 1:1, 14)
When	Days of Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah, c. 735–700 BC (Micah 1:1)
Audience	Samaria and Jerusalem, the two capitals (Micah 1:1)
Key people	Hezekiah; the prophet Isaiah, his contemporary
Main passages	Micah 1–7; Jeremiah 26:17–19
New Testament	Matthew 2:5–6; 10:35–36

"He hath shewed thee, O man, what is good; and what doth the LORD require of thee, but to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God?"

Micah 6:8, KJV

The life of Micah

Dates are approximate (BC). Micah does not date his individual messages, so the order below is partly a best guess.

- Before his call
At Moresheth

● A man from the lowlands
Micah grows up in a farming town southwest of Jerusalem, close to the border with the Philistines.
Micah 1:1, 14
- c. 735 BC
Days of Jotham

● The word comes
The word of the LORD comes to Micah concerning Samaria and Jerusalem. *Micah 1:1*
- Before 722 BC
Warning to the north

● Samaria will fall
He announces that Samaria will become a heap in the field, and that the same judgment is coming to the gate of Jerusalem. *Micah 1:2-9*
- c. 715-701 BC
Days of Hezekiah

● Zion will be ploughed
He warns that Jerusalem will be ploughed like a field for its leaders' sins. Hezekiah fears the LORD and prays, and the disaster is held back. *Micah 3:9-12; Jeremiah 26:18-19*
- Undated

● A ruler from Bethlehem
He foretells that a ruler in Israel will come from Bethlehem Ephratah, "whose goings forth have been from of old, from everlasting." *Micah 5:2-5*
- c. 609 BC
About a century later

● Quoted to save Jeremiah
When priests and prophets demand Jeremiah's death, some elders recall Micah's words and Hezekiah's response. *Jeremiah 26:1, 16-19, 24*

Group notes

Key activities

Micah 4:1–3 closely matches Isaiah 2:2–4. Scholars differ on whether one prophet borrowed from the other or both used an older saying. Micah is also a different man from Micaiah, who spoke to King Ahab (1 Kings 22).

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- 1 **Lamented his people's ruin.** He said he would wail and go stripped and barefoot because Judah's wound was incurable. *Micah 1:8–9*

 - 2 **Exposed land grabs.** He condemned those who lie awake planning evil and at morning light seize fields and houses. *Micah 2:1–2*

 - 3 **Confronted leaders.** He rebuked rulers who judged for bribes, priests who taught for hire, and prophets who divined for money. *Micah 3:1–11*

 - 4 **Spoke with God's power.** Unlike the false prophets, he said he was full of power by the Spirit of the LORD, to declare Israel's sin. *Micah 3:5–8*

 - 5 **Promised peace.** He foresaw a day when nations would "beat their swords into plowshares" and everyone would sit under his own vine and fig tree. *Micah 4:1–4*

 - 6 **Pointed to Bethlehem.** He foretold a ruler from the small town of Bethlehem who would shepherd God's people. *Micah 5:2–4*

 - 7 **Summed up God's will.** Not endless sacrifices, but justice, mercy and humble walking with God. *Micah 6:6–8*

 - 8 **Waited for God.** "Therefore I will look unto the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation." *Micah 7:7*

 - 9 **Praised God's mercy.** "Who is a God like unto thee, that pardoneth iniquity?" He will cast all their sins "into the depths of the sea." *Micah 7:18–19*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Micah.

Old Testament

Micah 1-7	The book of his prophecies
Jeremiah 26:17-19	Elders quote Micah 3:12 and help save Jeremiah's life
Echo: Isaiah 2:2-4	The same vision of peace, in the same years
Echo: Amos 5:24	Justice to "run down as waters"

New Testament

Matthew 2:5-6	Micah 5:2 tells Herod where the Christ would be born
John 7:42	The Christ comes "out of the town of Bethlehem"
Matthew 10:35-36	Jesus uses Micah 7:6 on divided households
Echo: Matthew 23:23	"Judgment, mercy, and faith," the weightier matters
Echo: Hebrews 8:12	God remembers our sins no more

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things does God require in Micah 6:8?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Micah links worship so closely with how people treat their neighbours?
3. *Apply:* Which of the three, justice, mercy or humility, is hardest for you right now? What would one step look like?
4. *Apply:* Micah's words changed a king. Whose words has God used to change your direction, and whom could you encourage this week?